The First Care Conversation Checklist

What to gather and talk through about Dad before you sit down with a professional.

Something happened with Dad, and this week there are conversations with the family, the caregivers and the care team, all at once. Before the next one, get these in hand. Check what you've done. An unchecked box is a job still open. It says nothing about Dad, or about you.

Gather

- [ ] The notes you already have about what happened, pulled into one place: texts, voicemails, the back of an envelope.
- [ ] The names of the family members and professionals involved this week, with a phone number or email for each. [1]
- [ ] Any care notes that already exist, such as a visit summary, a caregiver's notebook or the calendar on the fridge, collected with Dad's permission.
- [ ] Where Dad is living or staying right now, and who helps him there.

Confirm

- [ ] The event or change that started all this, in a sentence or two, with the day it happened.
- [ ] The care decisions that are coming up, and any date someone has given you. Beside each date, who said it.
- [ ] One family member as the contact for now, and a second as the backup.
- [ ] What each person actually does for Dad, checked with that person and not taken from what everyone assumes.
- [ ] How Dad's day goes now, in plain words: morning, daytime, evening and overnight.
- [ ] Which of your notes are confirmed facts, which are things the family has seen, and which are questions nobody has answered yet.

Discuss

- [ ] With the person who does the most for Dad: which responsibilities are becoming difficult.
- [ ] With Dad, where possible: what you've written down. Ask whether it sounds right to him and what he'd put differently.
- [ ] With the family: the same page, so everyone tells the story once and tells it the same way.

What this checklist doesn't do

It helps you gather, confirm and talk things through. It doesn't say whether Dad's arrangement is working or which choice the family should make. That's for the people who assess him, and for the next step below.

Ready for the next step?

You've gathered what you have and talked it through. The care interview goes on from there: it walks through Dad's living arrangement, his typical day and each area of daily life in order, checks what's been left out, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The item marked 1 follows AARP's Prepare to Care guide, which tells families to keep one list of contact information. The rest come from the Family Care Roadmap's own working list for this step.

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
